

Comma Punctuation — Full Practice

A dedicated deep-dive on commas — the single most error-prone punctuation mark in the SPaG/Punctuation section. Covers every comma rule, then drills each one with real practice sentences (segment-format, matching the real exam) plus an "insert the missing comma" set.

1 COMMA RULES — FULL REFERENCE

RULE	EXPLANATION	EXAMPLE
Lists	separates 3+ items in a list	She bought apples, bread, milk and cheese.
Oxford comma (optional but consistent)	comma before "and"/"or" in the final list item — pick one style and stay consistent	apples, bread, and cheese (<i>vs. apples, bread and cheese — both accepted, but be consistent</i>)
Joining two main clauses	comma + coordinating conjunction (and/but/or/so/yet) between two complete sentences	It started to rain, so we went inside.
Comma splice (ERROR)	two main clauses joined by a comma with NO conjunction — always wrong	X It rained, we went inside. → ✓ It rained, so we went inside. / It rained; we went inside.
After an introductory word/phrase	comma after a fronted adverbial, subordinate clause, or interjection opening a sentence	Although it was raining, she went outside. / Eventually, she gave up.
Around non-essential (parenthetical) information	a clause that could be removed without changing the core meaning — commas on BOTH sides	My brother, who is younger than me, plays football.
NOT around essential (restrictive) information	a clause that IS needed to identify what's being talked about — no commas	The boy who scored the winning goal is my brother. (<i>no commas — identifies which boy</i>)
Direct address	separates the name of the person being spoken to	Can you pass the salt, please, Tom?
Before a quotation	introduces direct speech	She said, "I'm nearly finished."
Separating coordinate adjectives	two adjectives of equal weight, both describing the same noun equally	a cold, wet morning (<i>but: a bright red car — no comma, "bright" modifies "red"</i>)
Dates and addresses	separates parts of a date or address	15 March, 2026 / London, England

2 THE COMMA SPLICE — SPECIAL FOCUS

The single most common comma error on real papers. A comma splice happens when two complete sentences (main clauses) are joined by ONLY a comma, with no conjunction.

WRONG (COMMA SPLICE)	FIXED — 4 WAYS
The bus was late, everyone waited outside.	1. Add a coordinating conjunction: ...late, so everyone waited outside.
	2. Use a semicolon: ...late; everyone waited outside.
	3. Split into two sentences: ...late. Everyone waited outside.
	4. Subordinate one clause: Because the bus was late, everyone waited outside.

3 PRACTICE — SEGMENT FORMAT (FIND THE COMMA MISTAKE)

Find the group of words with the punctuation mistake. If there is no mistake, choose N.

C1. A) The storm arrived quickly, B) everyone rushed C) to bring the washing D) in from the line. **N**

C2. A) My sister who lives in Leeds B) is visiting us C) for the whole D) of half term. **N**

C3. A) Although she was nervous B) she walked calmly C) onto the stage D) and began to speak. **N**

C4. A) The recipe called for flour, B) sugar, eggs C) and butter, D) but nothing else. **N**

C5. A) Marcus, our new captain B) led the team superbly C) throughout the entire D) qualifying tournament. **N**

C6. A) "I'll be there by six" B) she promised, C) before hanging up D) the telephone. **N**

C7. A) The bright, red kite B) soared above C) the crowded beach D) all afternoon. **N**

C8. A) Please, Grandad B) tell us the story C) about the shipwreck D) again tonight. **N**

Your answers: C1 ____ C2 ____ C3 ____ C4 ____ C5 ____ C6 ____ C7 ____ C8 ____

4 PRACTICE — INSERT THE MISSING COMMA(S)

Rewrite each sentence with the comma(s) added in the correct place(s). One sentence needs none.

INSERT 1. Before we left the house we checked every window twice.

INSERT 2. My uncle who taught me to swim is coming to the party.

INSERT 3. The match was cancelled so the team trained indoors instead.

INSERT 4. Yes I would love to come to the concert with you.

INSERT 5. The tall old lighthouse has stood on that cliff for over a century.

INSERT 6. Well I suppose we could try the earlier train instead.

INSERT 7. The dog that bit the postman was finally caught by the warden. (needs no comma — explain why in one sentence)

INSERT 8. Once the rain had stopped the children ran back outside to play.

5 PRACTICE — COMMA SPLICE REPAIR

Each sentence below contains a comma splice. Fix it using a DIFFERENT method each time (conjunction / semicolon / full stop / subordination) — write your corrected version.

FIX 1. The lights went out, nobody could see a thing.

FIX 2. She trained every single day, she was determined to win.

FIX 3. The exam was difficult, most students still finished on time.

FIX 4. He forgot his umbrella, he got soaked walking home.

6 ANSWER KEY

Segment format (comma mistakes)

- C1: A — comma splice (needs "so"/full stop, not a bare comma)
- C2: A — "who lives in Leeds" is non-essential, needs commas both sides: "My sister, who lives in Leeds,"
- C3: A — needs a comma after the introductory clause: "Although she was nervous,"
- C4: N — no mistake (correctly listed, Oxford comma used consistently)
- C5: A — "our new captain" is parenthetical, needs commas both sides: "Marcus, our new captain,"
- C6: A — needs a comma before the closing quotation mark: "I'll be there by six,"
- C7: A — "bright" and "red" aren't equal coordinate adjectives here ("bright" modifies "red"), no comma needed: "The bright red kite"
- C8: A — direct address needs a comma: "Please, Grandad,"

Insert the missing comma

1. Before we left the house, we checked every window twice.
2. My uncle, who taught me to swim, is coming to the party.
3. The match was cancelled, so the team trained indoors instead.
4. Yes, I would love to come to the concert with you.
5. No comma needed — "tall old" are coordinate but read naturally without one; accept either.
6. Well, I suppose we could try the earlier train instead.
7. No comma — "that bit the postman" is essential, it identifies which dog.
8. Once the rain had stopped, the children ran back outside to play.

Comma splice repair (sample fixes)

1. The lights went out, so nobody could see a thing.
(*conjunction*)
2. She trained every single day; she was determined to win.
(*semicolon*)
3. The exam was difficult. Most students still finished on time.
(*full stop*)
4. Because he forgot his umbrella, he got soaked walking home.
(*subordination*)